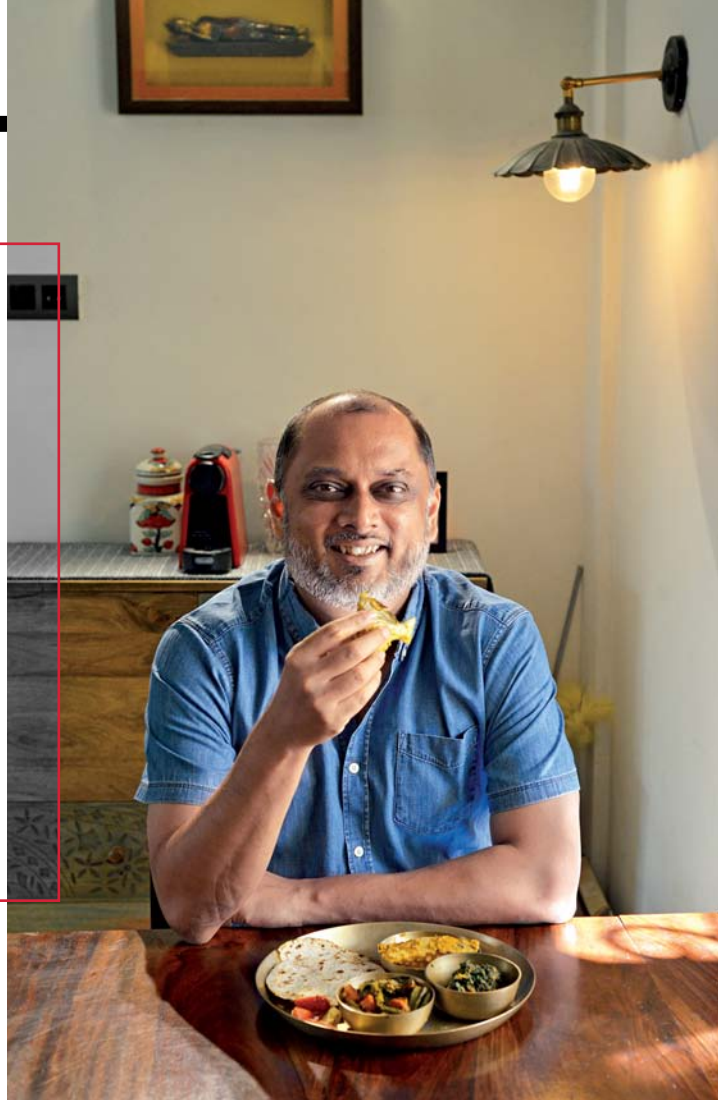
"I changed my approach to food to control my blood sugar after I got COVID-19. What has worked for me is that my dietician hasn't made dramatic changes. I am eating regular Indian food, nothing exotic or difficult to cook. The focus has been on healthy fat, carb and protein and it is working because it is simple to follow and I don't feel I am missing out on anything"

KALYAN KARMAKAR, 52
MUMBAI
Food blogger and author



MANDAR DEODHAR

says Dr Arvind. Thus, Keto needs to be followed under supervision and not for a long time. Minal Shah, a senior nutrition therapist from Fortis Hospitals, Mulund, Mumbai, says users must also adopt other healthy habits so that when the diet is over, they don't regain weight. "Those who have unhealthy eating practices need a change of mindset, not just of the menu."

UNDERSTANDING FOOD

As Indians get more mindful about their eating habits, it's important that they understand how food works. Consuming little or no carbohydrates, the body's main fuel, might help one lose weight, but it stresses out the mind and body. Similarly, sticking to only one food group and cutting out all others could cause nutritional deficiency. "It's not wrong to eat an ice cream occasionally if it makes you happy," says Shetty. Food is as much an emotional need as a biological one.

For many, though, these concepts remain shrouded in ignorance. Instead, their food habits are influenced by the internet and social media trends, where weight loss success stories are for everyone to see, but not the darker side of unsupervised diets. There are many, for instance, who fast—or starve—for long periods. "The person eats fried food one day and eats nothing the next two days. This causes so many digestive issues, erosion of the gut lining, harm to the gut bacteria, acidity," says Dr Arvind. Many others fashion their own health regimes. Ashwati Bose, a 22-year-old design intern in Pune, went from 98 kg to 90 kg in just two months and maintains a combination of three health apps—one for a meal plan, another to track calories, and a third to keep her motivated. "I was told if I didn't change my food habits, I would become infertile as my hormone production had dropped," she says. Her usual meals of burgers, fries, pizza and biryani have given way to cabbage soup, rice gruel, boiled eggs and oil-free salads. Bose doesn't know whether this will help her hormonal health, but she still wants to diet because "everyone says it will help".

Every year, the National Institute of Nutrition publishes a guideline for Indians, which includes meals according to activity level, gender and food group. Most experts agree with its recommendations—eat a balanced seasonal diet, reduce ultra-processed foods, be judicious about added sugar and salt, eat in moderate amounts at timely intervals, and exercise daily. "The best diet plan is one that is practical and sustainable," says Shetty. Other experts agree. "I would say Indians need to be re-taught how to eat. There is no shortcut to nutrition. Every gut is unique, and one size does not fit all," says Khosla.

The labyrinthine and ever-growing market for health can make one lose sight of the basics, and self-styled plans and 'shortcuts' often end up doing more harm than good. As Shetty says, you don't need that cauliflower crust pizza. It's a clearer, more prudent understanding of food and its relationship with the human body that's essential. ■